disable_functions = [function1, function2...]

A welcome addition to PHP4 configuration and one perpetuated in PHP5 is the ability to disable selected functions for security reasons. Previously, this necessitated hand-editing the C code from which PHP was made. Filesystem, system, and network functions should probably be the first to go because allowing the capability to write files and alter the system over HTTP is never such a safe idea.

max_execution_time = 30

The function set_time_limit() won.t work in safe mode, so this is the main way to make a script time out in safe mode. In Windows, you have to abort based on maximum memory consumed rather than time. You can also use the Apache timeout setting to timeout if you use Apache, but that will apply to non-PHP files on the site too.

error_reporting = E_ALL & ~E_NOTICE

The default value is E_ALL & ~E_NOTICE, all errors except notices. Development servers should be set to at least the default; only production servers should even consider a lesser value

error_prepend_string = [“”]

With its bookend, error_append_string, this setting allows you to make error messages a different color than other text, or what have you.

warn_plus_overloading = Off

This setting issues a warning if the + operator is used with strings, as in a form value.

variables_order = EGPCS

This configuration setting supersedes gpc_order. Both are now deprecated along with register_globals. It sets the order of the different variables: Environment, GET, POST, COOKIE, and SERVER (aka Built-in).You can change this order around. Variables will be overwritten successively in left-to-right order, with the rightmost one winning the hand every time. This means if you left the default setting and happened to use the same name for an environment variable, a POST variable, and a COOKIE variable, the COOKIE variable would own that name at the end of the process. In real life, this does not happen much.